

Cozy Little Dystopias: Cyberpunk Mechanics, Aesthetics and Themes in Independent Digital Games

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Deconstructeam's *The Red Strings Club* (2018) begins with the most stereotypically cyberpunk image imaginable: a cybernetically enhanced hacker and 'freelance hero' falling to his death from the top of a corporate skyscraper at night, through neon, in the rain. The image suggests yet another pastiche of well-worn chrome-and-neon aesthetics, but *The Red Strings Club* presents a deeply nuanced and modern take on cyberpunk as a narrative genre. Digital games are both well-suited to and intensely interested in cyberpunk, particularly as game development involves data-rich environments, artificial intelligence, prosthetic-like peripherals, virtual reality, and other systems and processes common in cyberpunk. But while the 'cyber' aspects come naturally to games, the 'punk' part is less common: aggressive, anti-authoritarian disillusionment with large global corporations, for example, is a difficult theme to address without hypocrisy for a game produced, marketed, and sold by exactly that kind of entity. Many games labeled as cyberpunk, particularly large scale or triple-A titles such as *Cyberpunk 2077* and *Final Fantasy VII Remake* (both 2020), adopt the cinematic visuals of cyberpunk but abandon its thematic content, rarely engaging with the transhumanist, anti-capitalist, reality-blurring aspects of the genre in any meaningful way.

Independent games, on the other hand, take more narrative and thematic risks than their large-scale counterparts due to their smaller production teams, experimental gameplay, and authorial authenticity. Indie games are particularly suited for cyberpunk narratives as their development structures and processes are less commercially-controlled and more personally authentic, as these games are commonly developed by teams of one, two, or up to a few dozen people, rather than the hierarchical, tightly structured teams of hundreds that develop triple-A games. Independent games have the potential to explore cyberpunk themes not only through aesthetics but also through experimental game mechanics, systems, and interactive narratives. The experience of playing games like *The Red Strings Club* (2018), *Stray* and *Citizen Sleeper* (both 2022) suggests a new way forward for a much-maligned and overused aesthetic genre.

Science Fiction and Cyberpunk in Digital Games

Digital games are a natural medium for science fiction narratives, in part because games are science fictional artifacts, dependent on rapidly changing computer technology (Evans 2020: 15). Historically, game developers have always been

science fiction fans. The first digital game ever created, *Spacewar!* (1962), came about because its programmers were reading E.E. Smith's Lensman series and thought that spaceships were the best possible thing to put on their new PDP-1 computer (Brand 1972). From the early 8-bit games of the 1970s and '80s to the massive triple-A titles being released today, a staggering number of science fiction games have been released, including classic arcade games like *Asteroids* (1980) and *Defender* (1981); long-running franchises like *Metroid* (1986), *X-COM* (1994), *Fallout* (1997), *Half-Life*, *StarCraft* (both 1998), *Halo* (2001) and *Mass Effect* (2007); critically acclaimed titles from *Deus Ex* (2000), *Portal* (2007) and *Bioshock* (2008) to *Nier: Automata*, *Horizon Zero Dawn* (both 2017) and *Returnal* (2021); indie darlings like *Kerbal Space Program* (2015), *Subnautica* (2018), *Outer Wilds* (2019) and *In Other Waters* (2020); beloved remakes like *Dead Space*, *Metroid Prime* and *System Shock* (all 2023); and even impressive initial flops like *No Man's Sky* (2016) and *Starfield* (2023). An equally staggering number of games can be classified as fantasy, horror or broadly speculative to the point that it is uncommon, if not rare, for a digital game to be set in a non-speculative, mundane world (Evans 2020: 15). Writing on digital science fiction, Pawel Freluk notes that 'most, if not all, video games are, in some way, science-fiction games', and that 'science-fictional regimes of thinking are absolutely central to the entire medium' (Freluk 2016). After nearly half a century of gaming, science fiction is clearly one of the most popular and most common narrative genres for modern digital games.

If science fiction is a natural fit for games, then cyberpunk is even more so, considering that digital game architecture and production processes are remarkably similar to those described in cyberpunk. Modern game development includes huge amounts of data and information processing, networked systems, artificially intelligent digital agents, hardware and near-prosthetic peripherals, virtual reality and augmented reality systems, and more recently AI-generated art, writing and content: all of which are bolstered, if not directly replicated, by science fiction narratives. For example, it is not unusual for a game to include fictional AI characters in its narrative and real AI characters in its environment. The machine intelligence HADES, antagonist of *Horizon Zero Dawn*, is a traditionally written, non-player character (NPC) and computationally simple compared to the complex ecology of AI-controlled dinosaur-like megafauna that the player hunts, tames and rides throughout the game, which were designed to 'behave differently depending on what the player does' (Francis 2018). In the case of cyberpunk, narratives about body modification, virtual reality and networked information landscapes are easily mapped on to game mechanics, systems and interfaces, so it is perhaps unsurprising that there are a wide variety of cyberpunk-themed games, including at least eight digital games in the

Shadowrun series (1993-2015); early titles like *Deus Ex*, *Beneath a Steel Sky* (1994), the original *System Shock* (1994) and *Syndicate Wars* (1996), and more recent games including *Gunpoint* (2013), *Transistor* (2014), *Remember Me* (2014), *Satellite Reign* (2015), *Deus Ex: Mankind Divided*, *VA-11 HALL-A* (both 2016), *Ruiner* (2017), *Observer* (2017), *Katana Zero* (2019), *Cyberpunk 2077*, *Final Fantasy VII Remake*, *Umurangi Generation*, *Cloudpunk* (both 2020), *The Ascent* (2021) and *Signalis* (2022), as well as many, many other titles.

Cyberpunk as a genre is a diverse, far-reaching and cross-cultural formation that has heavily influenced our technocultural age, to the point that 'cyberpunk is everywhere' (McFarlane et al 2020: 1-3). As is common in science fiction, the exact definition of cyberpunk is fluid, changeable and under constant discussion, but the core is generally consistent: the 'cyber' aspect describes a future controlled by global industrial-political blocs, marked by information density and networked virtual reality, in which humans alter their bodies and minds through mechanical, biological or cybernetic means, and in which narratives are concerned with themes of transhumanism, posthumanism, simulation and death (McFarlane et al 2020). The 'punk' aspect stands as 'a metaphor for rootlessness, alienation, and cultural dislocation [...] played out among the debris of sprawling urban conglomerates' (Cavallero 2000: 25), as well as an aggressive disillusionment with social identities, political structures and systems of capital (McFarlane et al 2020). Cyberpunk is particularly appealing to the computationally inclined, including game players and developers, as it presents the idea 'that technology did not have to be intimidating' and speaks to the 'sense of power and joy' computers could provide (Shiner 1991), not to mention the substantial cross-pollination between cyberpunk's visual aesthetic and the design of computer and game interfaces (Johnson 2018: 139-40).

When examining cyberpunk in digital games, two aspects need particular attention. First, while the term was coined by Bruce Bethke in 1983, William Gibson's *Neuromancer* (1984) remains the literary touchstone despite Gibson being 'notoriously ignorant of computer technology' (Clute 2003: 71). His imagining of cyberspace as 'the inside of the world of information was essentially a *literary coup*', meaning that the similarities between the current technological landscape and Gibson's vision exist 'because the world, and the writers who articulate the world, have imitated Gibson' (72), not the other way around. This reflexive design is particularly true for digital games, which are dependent on rapidly changing computer technology but also have a heavy influence on that technology's structure and development, including but not limited to rapid improvements in 2D and 3D computer graphics; the widespread adoption of CD storage systems in the '90s; the standardization and 'macintoshization' of

personal computer interfaces; and the development of virtual and augmented reality technology (Donovan 2010).

Second, while Gibson is the literary touchstone, the visual touchstone is Ridley Scott's *Blade Runner* (1982) with its stylish noir landscape of punk female androids, 'high-tech traffic alongside bicycles, its steam and smoke, its shabbiness and glitter cheek-by-jowl' (Nicholls and Lowe 2022), and its city 'drowning in advertisements' in which reality 'dissolves into the virtuality of mass media' (Brown 2010: 100). Digital games are a heavily visual medium, and those that label themselves as cyberpunk generally pull from this aesthetic, such that searching for the tag 'cyberpunk' in the Steam digital distribution system results in countless game titles with near-indistinguishable key art, all depicting wet, neon city streets at night, regardless of whether those titles are top-down action games like *Transistor*, horror games like *Observer* or driving sims like *Cloudpunk*. Digital game technology both influences and is influenced by visual descriptions of cyberspace in literature and film, as well as the aesthetics of cyberpunk across media, to the point that cyberpunk games are fixated on the graphical markers of cyberpunk above all else. Additionally, the visual language of digital games depends on clarity and transparency for the player, meaning that the way games 'display the vastness, complexity, and disorientation of multi-dimensional cyberspace' (Johnson 2018: 152-3) tends toward similar layouts and interactions between color, shape and space, making cyberpunk aesthetics even more familiar between individual games. In other words, cyberpunk games, almost to a fault, are visually impressive but not necessarily interested in cyberpunk's themes, regardless of how relevant those themes are to digital game design.

Criticisms of Cyberpunk in Digital Games

If cyberpunk is concerned with technology's 'immediate – that is, *unmediated* – effects upon human being-in-the-world' (Hollinger 2017: 45), then *Cyberpunk 2077*, one of the biggest-budget, best supported and most highly anticipated games of 2020, should have been a high watermark for the genre. Unfortunately, the game was roundly criticized for its shallow themes, weak narrative and hypocritical anti-capitalist stances, especially as one of the most expensive digital games ever made (Bowen 2021). Gibson himself called the game a *Grand Theft Auto* clone 'skinned-over with generic 80's retro future' (Wilde 2018). Many critics noted the difference between what *Cyberpunk 2077*'s narrative promised and what the mechanics delivered: 'all the gloss and chrome and affected, fake punkery gelled together like a hard shell in the first hours... [I was] told to act punk and do whatever I wanted but then offered only a narrow spread of pre-approved systemic options that usually broke down to a) shoot everyone, b) have sex with

a robot, c) buy things, d) quit' (Sheehan 2020). Narratively, the game often implies that society's problems are both insurmountable and unchangeable, encouraging the player to distract themselves through acquisition of ever more impressive cars, weapons and modifications, in essence conforming to the world's corrupt corporate structure. There are moments where the game's potential cyberpunk themes shine through, such as the editable braintance sequences and many of the optional sidequests, but never enough to impact the majority of the game's core experience. One reviewer described it as '*The Witcher 3* with cars' rather than cyberpunk (Plunkett 2023); another claimed the only truly punk option was not to play (Sheehan 2020). A third noted that *Cyberpunk 2077* feels derivative because so many of cyberpunk's accepted tropes and themes, particularly body modification and information-dense user interfaces, are now standard in digital games: 'After so many games like this, the chrome has worn off [...] It's not cyberpunk when it's just Videogame 101' (Chick 2020). After three years of additional development and the *Phantom Liberty* (2023) expansion, *Cyberpunk 2077* is much improved as a digital game but not as a work of cyberpunk, now functioning primarily as a politically charged spy thriller in an '80s inspired future (Kim 2023).

Likewise, *Final Fantasy VII Remake* is a high definition, visually immersive reimagining of the 1997 original, and takes place entirely in the grimy slums and industrial high-rises of the cyberpunk-influenced Midgar, a corporate-owned metropolis that is literally sucking the planet dry of life-giving energy. The first in a planned trilogy of games, *Remake* is a 'cyberpunk ecofable' full of greedy mega-corporations and anarchic heroes, in which the downtrodden 'find themselves taking violent action against the rapacious criminals running the show' (Casey 2020). Building on one of game history's most influential titles, *Remake* is less interested in cyberpunk than in questions of nostalgia, destiny, and digital games themselves. *Remake* completely reinvents the story and world of the original in a multitude of ways, particularly by including the Whispers, supernatural entities that seem hellbent on forcing the events of the original game to come to pass; and by implying that numerous major characters are aware of and attempting to change *Final Fantasy VII's* now near-folkloric story. The game has been called a 'radical, operatic act of subversion', one that is 'directly in dialogue with the player about what a remake can and probably should be', in which the final boss is a 'literal hideous embodiment of the hands of fate [...] It's a forceful, kinetic statement – that this remake should *not* be bound by what we already know' (Clark 2020). *Remake* rarely addresses the themes and narratives of cyberpunk because it is so heavily in conversation with themes of nostalgia, metafiction and games history (Booth and Jayemanne 2021; Hoch 2021; Bukač and Katić 2023).

Both *Cyberpunk 2077* and *Final Fantasy VII Remake* are visually arresting, deeply immersive games that are limited in how they address cyberpunk as a genre – a missed opportunity in one case, and a difference of thematic interest in the other. John Semley has argued that the shallowness of much current cyberpunk comes from a failure to look forward rather than back: ‘Where early cyberpunk offerings rooted through the scrap heap of genre, history, and futurist prognostication to cobble together a genre that felt vital and original, its modern iterations only have recourse to the canon of cyberpunk itself, smashing together tropes, cliches, and old hat ideas that [...] feel pathetically unoriginal’ (Semley 2019). Like film noir, steampunk and space opera, cyberpunk in large-scale games now primarily refers to a set of visual markers rather than to games that fundamentally explore ‘themes of who we are in a world where reality is so readily manipulated, where the digital and the incarnate intersect’ (Chick 2020), not to mention anti-corporate, anti-capitalist, and anarchic themes that are difficult to address in games developed and published by massive global corporations. For experimental narratives, themes and mechanics, as well as smaller, more individualized development structures, we should look not at large-scale game development but at independent games.

Examining Cyberpunk in Independent Games

In digital game development, we distinguish between ‘triple-A’ games, made by hundreds of professionals with budgets of hundreds of millions of dollars and distributed globally to the widest possible audience; and independent or ‘indie’ games, made by a smaller number of people with a narrower reach and often with more personal, experimental content. Game development team sizes exist on a spectrum, but indie games on the smaller end can be created by teams of twenty or thirty people, as with *Stray*; teams of three or four, as with *The Red Strings Club*; or even by a single developer, as with *Citizen Sleeper*. Indie game development has a strikingly different culture than the triple-A industry, and games at this scale have less funding, smaller scope and shorter development time, but indie developers also have far more freedom to make whatever they want than developers at larger commercial studios. Independent games are a particularly ripe space for cyberpunk, particularly considering how many indie games are created in innovative and personal punk-like environments.

When analyzing digital games, both independent and triple-A, one of the most widely referenced models is mechanics-dynamics-aesthetics (MDA), which frames a digital game as comprised of ‘systems that build behavior via interaction’, particularly when that behaviour is unpredictable (Hunicke et al 2004). Critically, the MDA model accounts for both the designer and player perspectives, in that designers consider how ‘mechanics give rise to dynamic

system behavior, which in turn leads to particular aesthetic experiences', while players see how 'aesthetics set the tone, which is born out in observable dynamics and eventually, operable mechanics' (Hunicke et al 2004). Other models also distinguish between a game's interactive mechanics and its narrative, aesthetic or environmental content (Salen and Zimmerman 2003; Juul 2005; Schell 2019), not to mention the long-standing debates over the relationship between a game's ludic aspects and narrative ones. For the purposes of this article, it is important to note two things: that digital games are a fundamentally interactive medium with great potential for narrative expression; and that narrative experiences in games are dramatically different than those in literature and film because of the medium's immersive, interactive qualities. It is also important to consider that narrative experiences in games vary widely: from linear and heavily cinematic stories (*The Last of Us* [2013]; *God of War: Ragnarok* [2022]) to traditional narratives threaded through expansive open worlds (*Ghost of Tsushima* [2018]; *The Legend of Zelda: Tears of the Kingdom* [2023]), and to narratives that would not be possible in a non-interactive medium, as with the reactive, antagonistic narration of *The Stanley Parable* (2013), the peeling-back of multiple environmental reveals in *Outer Wilds*, and the overwhelming number of possible narratives and outcomes in *Disco Elysium* (2019) and *Baldur's Gate 3* (2023).

Digital games also excel at expressing narrative themes through interaction. Some of the most effective games blend narrative experiences with mechanical ones, as with *The Swapper* (2013), a game about identity and selfhood in which the core mechanic involves creating, swapping between, and destroying up to five identical clones while quickly losing track of your 'real' self. Similarly, *Hades* (2020) is a combat-heavy roguelike, a game genre marked by 'tremendous difficulty, unpredictability, permanent character death, and the large number of methods they use to inflict that death' (Harris 2020: 2), which appropriately centres on Zagreus, Hades's son and demigod, whose story depends on his repeated deaths while attempting to escape his father's underworld. The potential for narrative through interactivity is especially powerful with cyberpunk, given the genre's focus on integrating technology with counterculture, 'the overlapping of [...] the realm of high-tech and the modern pop underground' (Sterling 1986: 345), as well as the many modern game mechanics and systems indebted to the structures of cyberpunk. In short, cyberpunk narratives and worlds can be explored, expressed and experienced differently in games than in other media; and independent games, which are often developed in less corporate, more 'punk' environments than triple-A games, represent a rich opportunity for reimagining the cultural relevancy of cyberpunk.

The Red Strings Club: Art, Technology, Ethics, and Bartending

As noted earlier, *The Red Strings Club* begins and ends with the same scene: cybernetic hero Brandeis falling to his death in the rain, with just enough time to give one piece of vital information to his romantic partner, Donovan, before he hits the ground. By genre, *The Red Strings Club* is a retro-styled adventure game influenced by visual novel design, particularly its emphasis on text and dialogue choices, in which the player controls three characters attempting to thwart Social Psyche Welfare, a corporate program that will utilize people's emotion-regulating implants to eliminate anger, fear, and depression from society. The megacorporation putting Social Psyche Welfare into place, Supercontinent, insists that this will save humanity, 'adamant that its technology is no different from a behavior-modifying medication' (Cox 2018); other characters consider it brainwashing, with one noting that 'society is about to become an operating system on which corporations will run whatever programs they please'. Rather than present either side as definitively correct, *The Red Strings Club* grapples immediately and thoroughly with cyberpunk themes by allowing its characters to argue about body/mind alteration, personal identity, and the moral ramifications of widespread technological modification.

Mechanically, *The Red Strings Club* is deliberately light with no combat, no fail states, and no intentionally difficult puzzles. Instead, the three-person development team 'focused on placing the challenge on the emotional side, to challenge the player's ideas [...] We want to communicate a message we consider very important, so we gave accessibility a big priority' (Calvin 2018). The game's mechanics are often experimental, such as the physics-based bartending sections in which Donovan, the club's owner and information broker, uses mixed drinks to manipulate his customers' emotional states before plying them for information. 'The irony of Donovan pumping people full of mind-altering chemicals in order to thwart a plot revolving around neurological manipulation isn't lost on the characters' (Cox 2018), particularly Akara-184, the first android that can make ethical decisions, who presses Donovan on his motivations after each encounter. Akara's gameplay sections involve designing emotion-regulating implants on what amounts to a biomatter pottery wheel, then strategically selecting different implants for various clients, with effects like 'filters online content to block any sort of negative stimuli' and 'eliminates the need for social acceptance'. Later, Akara gains access to implants designed by a revolutionary group, with more pointed effects like 'highly enhances your empathy and magnifies compassion' and 'induces aversion to corporations and rejection to authority', which can be implanted in Supercontinent's executives to varying effect. Choosing which clients should receive which implants, or which mind-altering drinks to offer each customer,

allows players to engage directly with the game's themes during play, while simultaneously reflecting on the complex societal and ethical implications of those choices.

Narratively, *The Red Strings Club* is a game 'about the attractions and the perils of self-improvement' in which free will, the social order, and how far we allow corporations to affect our lives are all under examination, and in which 'the villain is a system that posits technology as a savior from ourselves' (Campbell 2018). Rather than presenting Social Psyche Welfare as beneficial or malignant, the game lets its characters, from terrorists to corporate stooges, debate the program's implications. At one point, Akara-184 presses Donovan on the program's ideal parameters, asking 'Should I let hatred such as xenophobia or homophobia exist?' and 'Should I let people commit suicide?'. Many of the game's conversational threads are concerned with whether humanity needs pain and struggle to improve, how much struggle is worth enduring, and who decides what qualifies as a negative emotion. Donovan's club, and the game itself, are presented as a 'zero judgment zone, where the marginalized and merely interested (including the player) can discuss these questions in safety' (Strom 2018). By refusing easy answers and a clear victory, the game allows players to reflect on these topics themselves, 'not prescribing nor offering an ethical positioning, staying in a moral ambiguity on whether the main characters are doing the correct thing or not in a plot that revolves around the notion of identity' (García and Lizana 2023: 248).

The Red Strings Club ends exactly where it began with Brandeis falling to his death with only enough time to tell Donovan one thing: either the secret to stopping Social Psyche Welfare, a potentially impossible task, or that he loves him. While the choice does not affect the game's outcome, it is both deeply affecting and a remarkably difficult choice in the moment of play. In the very last moment of the game, the player as Donovan pours themselves a drink that will induce amnesia, implying that for all their discussions of empathy, negative emotions and the value of struggle, Donovan cannot live with the pain of Brandeis's memory. The game's developers use these sorts of choices to tell an explicitly emotional cyberpunk story, noting that literature contains 'many great cyberpunk works that aren't about noise, violence, and shiny lights. Cyberpunk was an excellent setting for us to explore the kind of questions our narrative poses' (Calvin 2018). Ultimately, *The Red Strings Club* is an example of how limited mechanics and an emphasis on mechanically interesting choices can use the medium of games to tell an emotionally affecting cyberpunk story.

Stray: Safe and Cozy Cyberpunk

At first glance, cyberpunk and 'cozy' game aesthetics seem entirely opposed. Cozy games are a relatively recent genre aesthetic (Cook 2018), marked by relaxing

gameplay; feelings of comfort and safety; soft or pastel colour palettes; and low-stress narratives and content. Coziness is defined as ‘how strongly a game evokes the fantasy of safety, abundance, and softness’, achieved through absence of risk, gentle and comforting stimuli, and intimate low-stress environments (Meiners 2017). Cozy games are also feminist and inclusive, designed with women and ‘queer and alternative genders, including soft masculinities’ in mind (Waszkiewicz and Bakun 2020: 225). Cozy games include *Animal Crossing: New Horizons* (2020); indie games like *Stardew Valley* (2016), *A Short Hike* (2019), *Carto* (2020) and *Unpacking* (2021); cross-genre games like *Spirittfarer* (2020), a ‘cozy management game about dying’ consistently noted as one of the most painful, heartbreaking games about death and grieving ever made (Eum et al 2021: 1; Glaser et al 2022); and *Night in the Woods* (2017), *Cozy Grove* (2021) and *Strange Horticulture* (2022), which blend coziness with unsettling horror-themed content. Cozy games and their soft, safe, feminine aesthetics may seem mutually exclusive with the high-octane, aggressively masculine, anarchic cyberpunk genre, yet BlueTwelve Studio’s *Stray* manages exactly that by presenting a player character that is both deeply anti-authoritarian and inherently soft and cozy: a house cat. *Stray* also achieves cyberpunk coziness by filling its data-rich, Asian-inspired environments with compassionate, empathetic characters that the player can mechanically care for. These two aspects allow *Stray* to seamlessly blend cyberpunk aesthetics and themes with cozy aesthetics and mechanics.

Stray’s environment is a familiar one, a domed city in constant darkness heavily inspired by Hong Kong and the Walled City of Kowloon (Bedingfield 2022), although without reckoning with that city’s painful history, an all-too-common pitfall for cyberpunk (Jiang 2022). It is also unusual in that there are no humans. With the exception of companion drone B-12, eventually revealed to be a digitized human consciousness, every character in the game is a sentient robot, most of whom consider humans a myth. From a level design perspective, *Stray* centers on small explorable hubs between traditional action-platforming areas, and these hubs are decidedly cozy in nature. The first, titled simply The Slums, includes some of the game’s most arresting images, including ‘a robot in a flamingo dress’ pulling ‘open a blind to reveal a radio tower [...] against an array of stars’ (Bedingfield 2022); a robot named Grandma knitting a poncho out of electric cables, in case the player meets any robots that are cold (which, of course, they do); and a robot with a guitar who plays music, during which the cat will curl up on a nearby pile of pillows and purr while listening. Both the environment and the game’s quest design emphasize that this world is compassionate and lived-in, and that the majority of robots care for, worry about, and support each other. One critic called it a ‘a world of lighthearted dystopia’ in which characters ‘cultivate plants that can survive under the darkness of the

dome, just because people would have liked that' (Conditt 2022). The anti-establishment spirit of cyberpunk thrives in *Stray* as well, especially among the revolutionaries of The Slums, anarchic painters of Antvillage, and breakdancing music punks of Midtown, but even these characters, with a very few exceptions, are caring, compassionate, and thematically cozy.

Mechanically, *Stray* emphasizes the player's catness, both through the game's impressive verticality and nook-and-cranny-ness, allowing for detailed exploration of the environment in a strikingly non-human way; and through meticulous art, animations and game feedback. Details like 'acrobatic leaps from perch to perch, the butt-wagging low crawl [...] cozy spots to sleep, including a nice warm robot belly,' and the ability to 'push objects off of shelves, scratch on doors to be let in, carry items in my mouth, and trip over unsuspecting robots' make the player's inherent catness 'a constant delight' (Ong 2022). The game's developers, who include three cats on their core development team, prioritized game feel in their design such as subtle feedback on the controller trigger buttons when scratching on trees or furniture, or vibrating the controller when the main character purrs such that it 'feels like you're holding a kitten in your hand' (Madsen 2022). As well as a cat's fundamental coziness, the anti-authoritarian, anarchic attitude of house cats is also present. In individual moments, the player can knock over paint cans or ruin a robot's game of mah-jongg; in a larger, strategic sense, players can ignore *Stray*'s main narrative entirely, and do everything or nothing without being chastised or pushed forward by the game's systems.

Stray's attention to worldbuilding is consistent throughout, expressed through a myriad of details, 'whether it's an environmental cue nudging players toward a specific path or the ability to meow at will' (Conditt 2022). Even the traditional markers of cyberpunk are softer-edged, down to the slightly muted neon environment. The developers were interested in that disparity early on, particularly 'the contrast between the cats being small, alive, and cute, and the machines being a bit more cold and angular' (Madsen 2022), which led them to a cozier, more compassionate take on cyberpunk tropes. *Stray*'s themes of transhumanism, digital consciousness, pervasive technology and freedom versus security are realized within a comfortable, curious and abundant environment that also serves as a digital playground for a virtual cat. *Stray*'s cyberpunk coziness makes a clear argument for blending cyberpunk with other genres, aesthetics and mechanics, leading to fresh and newly-relevant experiences in digital games.

Citizen Sleeper: Precarity, Bodily Autonomy, and The Now

If the criticism of cyberpunk games is that they look backward instead of forward, *Citizen Sleeper* is cyberpunk concerned with the now, inspired as it is by our 'modern dystopia' and its passive corporate cruelty (Russell 2022), the perils of

'gig work', and the current fight for bodily autonomy (Bea 2022). Players control a Sleeper, a digitized human mind that has been sold to a corporation and downloaded into an artificial body, attempting to escape perpetual indentured servitude by scrounging out a new life on the decaying space station Erlin's Eye, a habitat that bears all the hallmarks of late-stage global, or galactic, capitalism. Mechanically, *Citizen Sleeper* pulls from both interactive narrative and tabletop roleplaying games, but is thematically concerned with 'precarity', a word that creator Gareth Damian Martin kept posted to their computer screen during the entirety of development (Evans 2023). The game's mechanics are tuned to keep the player on the edge of failure: always out of food, stamina, dice, time, or the Stabilizer injections required to stay functional. Every minor setback has the potential to become a major tragedy: 'Can you afford to wait a little longer to pay an unsavory character's protection money? Is it worth spending one die on working for a meal [...] or is it better to skip food altogether with the hopes of eking out the most progress toward a prospective reward?' (Scaife 2022). In this sense, *Citizen Sleeper* has much in common with survival games like *The Long Dark* (2017) and *Subnautica* (2019), except that instead of the frigid Canadian wilderness or a hostile alien ocean, players are struggling to survive against capitalism itself, through game mechanics structured to convey 'the tension of hanging by a thread in an unforgiving environment' (Scaife 2022).

Digital games are no stranger to visual representations of cyberspace, but *Citizen Sleeper* handles its technological aspects not only through aesthetics but also mechanics and user interface design. Early on, players are given access to The Net, the information network that overlays and controls much of the station, presented as a latticed grayscale overlay of Erlin's Eye. Unlike *Cyberpunk 2077* or *Deus Ex: Human Revolution* (2011), hacking in *Citizen Sleeper* is more than an occasional minigame: players are constantly engaged with the digital citizens of the Net, pulling data from broadcasting agents, station areas, and a variety of digital life forms, from the dangerous Hunter and Killer protocols to the transcendent Gardener that tends part of the station. Players generally spend as much time in the Net as in the physical station, emphasizing the Sleeper's cybernetic, transhuman qualities through gameplay. With the Net, *Citizen Sleeper* also wrangles with the irresistible pull of pervasive technology: that 'cyberpunk reveals [how] technology seeks to control us at the same time that it dramatizes the cyberpunk apocalypse: we have met the enemy and he is us' (Porush 1992: 257). Many of the questlines in the Net end with the temptation of dissolution: that the Sleeper can choose to abandon their artificial body and sleeping human predecessor to become an incorporeal, entirely digital being. This is not a win or lose state but simply a potential ending, one that players are invited to consider as either transcendent, tragic, or both.

Narratively, *Citizen Sleeper* is intensely interested in the effects of living in a post-capitalist cyberpunk society, especially the toll that banal, repetitive work takes on individual people: 'Succeeding in *Citizen Sleeper* means risking your body to perform labor, and clawing control of it back by taking stabilizing drugs made by an exploitative corporation' (Bea 2022). Martin notes that the game's characters were inspired by their own life experience, in that 'pretty much all the characters have had their minds or bodies affected by the labor they do, and half of them are based on people I met working agency jobs' (Bea 2022). The stories of Erlin's Eye are marked by difficult choices: whether to tell bounty hunter Ankhita that you have found her missing crewmate, whose betrayal was driven by love for a Sleeper like yourself; to trust Ethan, the first bounty hunter to come after you, in hopes that he can stave off worse and harder mercenaries; to kill or endlessly cage the Killer station protocol; to leave with shipyard worker Lem and his adopted daughter Mina on the colony ship *Sidereal Horizon*, abandoning any hope of finding out who you were but gaining a family instead... Many of these decisions involve danger and risk, but none require speed, adrenaline or power. These are ethically complex choices, all of which invite the player to reflect on the game's themes of pervasive technology, bodily autonomy and capitalist stagnation.

The act of playing a digital game can often be seen as an asynchronous conversation with its developers, and this is particularly true for games made by one person. *Citizen Sleeper* and its creator both have a great deal to say about the state of the world, as well as cyberpunk itself. Martin comments that cyberpunk can feel stagnant because it still draws 'on those same structures that were concerns for Gibson [and] Ridley Scott in the 70s and 80s [...] I modeled [*Citizen Sleeper*] around things in our society now like constant pressure, exposure to risk, the feeling that luck is the only thing that is keeping you with a roof over your head' (Colbert 2022). It may not have the visual immediacy of a *Cyberpunk 2077* or a *Final Fantasy VII Remake*, but *Citizen Sleeper* is arguably one of the most relevant modern cyberpunk games, concerned less with stereotypical aesthetic trappings than with the technological, societal, and science fictional concerns of the now, presenting a vibrant way forward for cyberpunk as a genre.

Cyberpunk and the Future of Indie Games

Digital games are extremely effective at the following things: putting you in someone else's shoes, immersing you in believable but impossible worlds, and making you feel like your choices matter even in a deterministic, computer-controlled fictional system. As a medium, games have the potential to tell powerful stories driven by interaction, immersion and technology, and are particularly suited for the post-capitalist, transhumanist, reality-blurring nature of cyberpunk. Isaiah Colbert has argued that most current cyberpunk games have misinterpreted the genre:

While it's easy to become enveloped in the power fantasy and the magnificence of transhumanism, these games haven't spent enough time reflecting on the problems that stem from our relationships with these technologies. Cyberpunk should be an inspection into and a commentary on the power structures that define our world. (Colbert 2022)

In the same interview, Martin argues that game developers should focus on the aspects of cyberpunk that are relevant to today: 'I don't think that Gibson and [Bruce] Sterling were writing about the future. I think they were writing about the moment they were in [...] We should continue to make cyberpunk work about the moment we're in' (Colbert 2022). The present is rife with technological issues that cyberpunk can address: body modification, transhumanism, big data, and virtual reality are far more pressing now than they were in 1984, and problems inherent to pervasive technology such as the loss of privacy, loss of bodily autonomy, and the slow slide into post-capitalist dystopia are well worth examining.

Additionally, neither cyberpunk nor digital games are as male-dominated as they were in the 1980s. *Stray* is cozy and feminine; *The Red Strings Club* is unabashedly queer, and one of its three developers is a trans woman; *Citizen Sleeper's* sole developer is nonbinary and the game centres characters of multiple genders and sexual orientations. Considering concerns that cyberpunk has been a 'phallocratic movement' with Pat Cadigan the only woman writer regularly associated with it (Nicholls 2024), as well as criticisms of the sexist treatment of women and transgender characters in *Cyberpunk 2077* (Henley 2021), gender and sexuality are one area in which independent cyberpunk games are demonstrably more progressive, and leading the way forward by example. These games consistently present cyberpunk worlds and stories that are intensely relevant to modern concerns, rather than simply adopting the rain-and-neon aesthetic that dominates cyberpunk media. Independent cyberpunk games embody both the 'punk' and 'cyber' aspects of the genre by expressing cyberpunk themes through mechanics, systems and interactions, and are reinvigorating the genre by using cyberpunk as a lens to explore, examine, and reflect on both current and near-future concerns. As with all narrative genres, digital games present an immersive, interactive medium for storytelling, the potential of which has still barely been explored. With cyberpunk in particular, independent games are proving a rejuvenating force, bringing new narrative structures, thematic relevance, and a chrome-bright potential future to cyberpunk in digital games.

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CALL FOR PAPERS

Special section on SF of the 1870s

To mark the 150th issue of *Foundation* in spring 2025, we would like to include contributions on the topic of sf from 150 years ago, published during the 1870s. Darko Suvin once proposed 1 May 1871 as the starting-point for sf – the day that Edward Bulwer-Lytton's *The Coming Race* was published, George Chesney's *The Battle of Dorking* began serialisation, and Samuel Butler submitted *Erewhon* to his publisher. Jules Verne, however, was already in full swing and he would soon be joined by such contemporaries as Camille Flammarion. Where else can we trace the roots of science fiction in the 1870s? How can we reassess the writers we know and who are the writers we need to rediscover?

We welcome articles on any aspect of science fiction published between 1870 and 1880. Articles should be 5000-8000 words long and written in accordance with the style guide available on the website (www.sf-foundation.org/journal). Topics may include but are not limited to the following:

- Ideas of utopia
- Humans and machine technology
- The impact of evolution and the biological sciences
- Sf and the invasion novel
- Sf and astronomy
- Satire and allegory
- Science and pseudo-science
- Space travel and other worlds
- Exploration and voyages of discovery
- Race and empire
- Gender and sexuality
- Arnold, Huxley and the 'two cultures' debate
- Sf and the non-anglophone world

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